When it Hurts to Ask: Consumer Reactance to Tip Prompts

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Purpose

Digital payment systems have expanded tipping into contexts where tipping norms are unclear. We examine when and why prompting consumers to tip leads to negative consumer responses.

Design/methodology/approach

Across two pilot studies and four scenario-based experiments (total $N = 1{,}274$), we examine consumer reactions to the presence versus absence of a tip prompt across normative and non-normative service contexts. We draw on social norms theory and psychological reactance to test boundary conditions and underlying mechanisms.

Findings

Tips prompted in non-normative contexts (e.g., café drive-thrus) harm satisfaction, brand attitudes, word-of-mouth, and repatronage intentions. These effects are driven by consumer reactance arising from perceived threats to autonomy and norm violations. Reinforcing consumers' sense of choice, such as through frontline employee intervention, mitigates these effects.

Originality/value

Research implications. We extend tipping and service marketing literature by shifting focus from tipping magnitude to the act of soliciting a tip, and by identifying context normativity as a critical boundary condition and reactance as a key psychological mechanism underlying negative responses to tip prompts in non-normative settings.

Practical implications. Managers in industries where tips are non-normative should carefully consider the decision to implement tip prompt procedures as well as the service scripts front-line employees use.

Social implications. Negative consumer responses to tip prompts in non-normative contexts could eventually shift responses to all tip prompts, ultimately destabilizing revenue streams for businesses and earning potential of low-wage employees.

Keywords: tipping, social norms, reactance, tip prompts, service encounters, service outcomes, choice architecture, consumer autonomy

Introduction

Tipping is a long-established norm in many cultures (Lynn, 2006) whereby consumers voluntarily offer payment above and beyond a listed price. Typically engaged in to indicate appreciation for good service (e.g., at sit-down restaurants), for many industries, tipping represents the outcome of a social contract: the consumer is obligated to provide a tip, provided acceptable levels of service were delivered. Recently, widespread adoption of digital payment systems has led to changes in the way businesses solicit tips. Today's consumers find themselves being prompted to tip at an increasingly wide array of businesses, including airports, coffee shops, drive-thrus, retail shops, and even self-service checkout counters (Steinberg, 2023; Wolfe, 2023). Whereas tipping norms dictate that tips are expected for services in which personal service is provided by human employees, and that tips are proffered following receipt of service, consumers are increasingly receiving tip solicitations prior to consumption of the service and/or in the absence of human service provision. These circumstances have consumers wondering what they are tipping for, where their money is going (Liew, 2023; Barnea, 2023), and increasingly frustrated (e.g., Bitter 2025). In short, they raise the question of whether consumer perceptions of tipping may be shifting.

The present research seeks to examine the extent to which present-day consumers react negatively to tip prompts, whether such negative responses are isolated to norm-breaking (i.e., non-normative) contexts, and what psychological responses underlie these potential effects. In

doing so, we make three core contributions. First, this research contributes to the tipping literature by shifting focus from tipping behaviour and tip magnitude to consumer responses to being solicited for a tip. While tipping has long been understood as part of a social contract contingent on acceptable service delivery (Lynn, 2006), recent work has only begun to examine how consumers respond to the act of tip solicitation itself (e.g., Cabano & Attari, 2023; Karabas et al., 2020; Warren & Hanson, 2023). We extend this emerging research by demonstrating that tip prompts can elicit negative downstream consumer outcomes, even in the absence of any actual tipping decision, thereby broadening the scope of tipping research beyond financial outcomes to include consumer evaluations and relationship-relevant responses.

Second, this research advances theory by identifying context normativity as a critical boundary condition for consumer reactions to tip prompts. Drawing on Bicchieri's (2016) theory of social norms, we show that tip prompts are not universally aversive; rather, negative responses emerge in non-normative contexts where expectations about tipping are weak or ambiguous. In doing so, we clarify when tip solicitations violate normative expectations and demonstrate how such violations shape consumer perceptions and evaluations.

Finally, we identify psychological reactance as a key mechanism that links non-normative tip prompts to negative consumer outcomes. We demonstrate that when consumers perceive a tip prompt as norm-violating, they experience heightened reactance stemming from perceived threats to autonomy, which in turn leads to reduced satisfaction, weaker brand attitudes, lower repatronage intentions, and diminished word-of-mouth. This contribution extends prior work on customer irritation (Karabas et al. 2020) by showing how autonomy threats translate into broader and more consequential downstream effects. Drawing on the above

contributions, we advance managerial understanding of tip prompts and suggest that tip prompts are not simply a low-risk revenue tool; their effectiveness depends critically on context.

Literature Review

A tip is a voluntary payment of money from a customer to a service provider (above and beyond a listed price; Azar, 2020; Lynn & Graves, 1996; Lynn & Latané 1984). Though tipping is arguably an economically irrational behavior (Azar, 2020), a self-interested consumer should desire to pay as little as possible for their purchases and instead save money for other uses (Ben-Zion & Karni, 1977), tipping is nevertheless a common practice across many societies (Dyussembayeva *et al*., 2022).

So why do consumers tip? While motivations for tipping include ensuring future service quality (e.g., Azar 2020) and altruism (e.g., to compensate low incomes of service employees; Lynn & Grassman, 1990), the strongest driver of tipping is that it is a socially normative behavior (Azar, 2010). Indeed, social norms exert such strong influences that consumers often tip even in situations where they are dissatisfied with their consumption experiences (Lynn, 2001).

Tipping as a Social Norm

According to Bicchieri's theory of social norms (2016), a social norm is "a rule of behavior such that individuals prefer to conform to it on the condition that they believe that a) most people in their reference network conform to it, and b) that most people in their reference network believe they ought to conform to it" (p. 35). That is, individuals' likelihood of following social norms depends on the extent to which they believe others in the same situation would do so—what Bicchieri calls "empirical expectations". A social norm arises when a group has shared reasons to act and group coordination is leveraged to establish the norm. The norm is then reinforced and strengthened over time through a combination of negative and positive sanctions (Bicchieri 2016). Expected outcomes of tipping align with a sanctions-based model: these include avoidance of social disapproval, embarrassment, rejection, and feelings of guilt (Azar,

2003; Furnham, 2021; Lee *et al*., 2020), and desire to gain social approval from service employees (Lynn & Grassman, 1990).

Notably, norms are established due to collective reason – there is a shared perceived benefit to its existence. Norms in the absence of benefit to the consumer tend to erode over time. Yet, despite being economically irrational for an individual consumer, tipping remains common practice, suggesting that the perceived reasons for the norm (e.g., ensuring service employees earn a living wage, providing a means for consumers to indicate service approval) persist and provide value to the collective (Azar, 2005).

The Role of Context in Tipping Behavior

Assuming that the primary collective reasons for the establishment of tipping as a social norm consisted of 1) supplementing low-wage employees' incomes and 2) desiring social approval of service employees, tipping should be more prominent in contexts that align with these motivations. Consistent with this perspective, extant research describes tipping as most prevalent in industries where workers deliver personalized service and receive relatively lower incomes (Azar, 2005; Lynn, 2016). For instance, commonly tipped service workers include bartenders, barbers, baristas, casino dealers, concierges, cruise cabin stewards, delivery drivers, doormen, exotic dancers, golf caddies, musicians, masseurs, parking valets, tour guides, and sommeliers (Lynn, 2016; Star, 1988). Through this lens, a clear image of tipping norm parameters takes shape: tips are normative when identifiable, human service workers have provided a valued service to a consumer. They are also more likely to be provided when the service worker has a relatively low income, and when the service provided has been personalized (Azar 2005).

Tipping in New Contexts

While tip contexts have historically aligned with consumer motivations, as outlined above, automated point-of-sale technologies and digital payment systems have begun to disrupt tipping practice and change the way customers and service providers interact (Warren & Hanson, 2023). As electronic forms of payment have become prevalent, consumers have become more familiar with digital screens prompting decision-making tasks (such as tip prompts; Haggag & Paci, 2014; Hoover, 2022). The adoption of automated point-of-sale technologies has been credited for the extension of tipping practice into new contexts, including previously untipped services such as quick-service dining restaurants, retail shops, online shops, and digital donation platforms (Warren & Hanson, 2023). Organizational decisions to insert tip prompts in these non-normative contexts are likely motivated by desire for incremental revenue gains coupled with ease (front line workers' service scripts need not change).

As tipping practice extends beyond traditionally-tipped services, however, consumers' motivation to tip becomes less clear. Social norms only apply when situations are "sufficiently similar to each other" (Bicchieri, 2016, p. 30), and we suggest that many emerging tip contexts may fail to meet this criterion. For instance, while quick service or drive-thru restaurants are superficially similar to sit-down restaurants in that they provide food, they lack one of the foundational justifications for tipping – personalized service. We argue that when the primary collective reasons underlying the tipping norm no longer apply, consumers may perceive the request as normatively inappropriate.

According to Bicchieri's (2016) theory of social norms, such questioning reflects a breakdown in the conditions required for norm compliance, as individuals no longer view the norm as relevant or legitimate in a situation that lacks social approval or supplementing wages.

In this case, rather than prompting consumers to follow a norm, firms may instead open themselves to perceptions of norm violation. Consumers are generally motivated to punish firms they see as norm-violating. For example, firms that are perceived as engaging in norm-breaking pricing tactics (such as charging different prices for the same good based on customer attributes) incur reduced purchase intentions and greater negative word of mouth (Garbino and Maxwell 2010). We propose that attempts to enforce a norm that is perceived as inapplicable are more likely to be experienced as unwarranted constraints on choice and result in negative consumer reactions.

> **H1:** The extent to which tipping a service is perceived as normative will moderate the effects of a tip prompt on consumer outcomes, such that the negative effect of a tip prompt is stronger for non-normative services than for normative services.

Reactance

Consequently, encountering a tip prompt under non-normative conditions should heighten perceptions of autonomy threat and elicit psychological reactance, as consumers resist what they perceive to be an unjustified attempt to influence their behavior (Brehm, 1966). Consumer reactance is an unpleasant motivational state that results when individuals perceive a lack of control and feel that their autonomy is threatened (Brehm, 1966; Clee & Wicklund, 1980). Threats to a consumer's autonomy can be constituted by any influences or barriers which may prevent one from taking their intended action (Clee & Wicklund, 1980). Of particular relevance to the present research, pressures to comply to requests can induce reactance (Brehm, 1966). Whether such pressures are experienced as threatening can depend on context norms:

when a request is non-normative, requests are more likely to be perceived as unwarranted and autonomy-threatening (White & Simpson, 2013). Accordingly, reactance will be heightened when consumers perceive a request to be improper or unjustified (Berkowitz, 1973; Clee & Wicklund, 1980; Fitzsimons & Lehmann, 2004; Reimer & Benkenstein, 2016).

Reactance motivates individuals to restore their freedom, through direct or indirect behaviors (Brehm, 1966). One such set of behaviors consists of negative consumer responses towards the source of threat (Clee & Wicklund, 1980). For example, reactance arising in response to assertive ads induces negative consumer perceptions of the communicating brand (Bhattacharjee *et al*., 2014; Edwards *et al*., 2002; Kronrod *et al*., 2012). Similarly, reactance in response to promotional favors results in consumers choosing cheaper or fewer options and ultimately spending less money compared to typical discount-oriented promotions (Bertini & Aydinli, 2020). In sum, reactance can facilitate lower satisfaction (Ku *et al*., 2013), negative sentiments (Massetti *et al*., 2019), and poor behaviors (Acuti *et al*., 2022).

H2: Reactance will mediate the relationship between tip prompt and consumer outcomes.

[insert Figure 1 about here]

We next present our empirics as follows. First, we conduct two pilot studies to i) confirm that consumers are experiencing tip prompts in new contexts, ii) determine the extent to which consumers consider tip prompts from varying contexts to be normative. Next, we test our hypotheses across a set of four experiments (total N = 1,269). Study 1 manipulates tip prompt and context normativity to confirm that our theory applies only to non-normative contexts. Study

2 further tests whether perceptions of non-normativity drive negative consumer response to tip prompt by placing all participants in a non-normative context and measuring expectations of receiving a tip prompt. Study 3 provides initial evidence of reactance as the mechanism underlying our effects, while study 4 replicates these mediation findings while additionally demonstrating a managerially-actionable intervention. Studies 1, 3, and 4 were pre-registered.

Method

Pilot Study 1

We asked 99 American and Canadian MTurk participants (M_{age} = 40.0; 37.4% female) to indicate up to five situations where they could recall being asked to provide a tip in the past year. For exploratory purposes we also then asked if any of these situations struck them as particularly unusual (open-ended), and whether they could recall having an emotional reaction to being asked for a tip in the past (open-ended). This pilot resulted in the identification of 42 distinct tipping contexts. See table 1 for a complete list.

[Insert Table 1 about here]

The data highlighted that different roles in an organization were considered distinct tipping contexts. For example, participants distinguished between restaurant servers and restaurant hosts. Participants also distinguished between types of businesses in the same category, such as pizzerias vs. fast-food restaurants vs. cafeterias vs. food trucks. These distinctions suggest that consumers are indeed sensitive to the degree of individualized, human-provided service when considering whether tipping is appropriate. In addition, qualitative

responses about unusual contexts indicated coffee shops, airport stores, self-checkouts, and fast food as common answers. In terms of emotions, participants expressed two: frustration and guilt.

Pilot Study 2

Our second pilot study sought to determine consumer perceptions of tipping norms across varying contexts. We recruited 200 American and Canadian participants from Prolific Academic (M_{Age} = 35.4, 53% female). We selected 40 tip contexts from pilot 1 that were judged by the research team to be reasonably distinct from one another. Each participant was randomly assigned 10 tip contexts and indicated how normal they would consider it to be asked to tip in each situation (1 = highly abnormal, 7 = highly normal). This resulted in each context being evaluated approximately 50 times. See Figure 2 for rank-ordered results.

[Insert Figure 2 about here]

Results demonstrated high variance in the extent to which consumers perceive a tip prompt to be normal as a function of context. The most normative tipping contexts included restaurant servers (M = 6.60, SD = .97), food delivery drivers (M = 6.26, SD = 1.23), hair salons (M = 5.76, SD = 1.62), barbers (M = 5.72, SD = 1.49), valets (M = 5.68, SD = 1.63), and restaurant hosts (M = 5.62, SD = 2.08). The least normative contexts were retail outlets such as clothing, vape, antique, grocery, and convenience stores, limited-service offerings such as fast-food drive-thrus, dress fitting services, and food courts, and professional services such as auto mechanics and plumbers. Interestingly, several contexts hovered around the midpoint of the scale, including restaurant take-out (M = 3.88, SD = 2.20), café take-out (M = 3.94, SD = 2.01),

moving companies (M = 4.04, SD = 2.02), tour guides (M = 4.02, SD = 1.91), and pet services such as grooming (M = 4.28, SD = 1.51). In sum, a clear continuum of normativity emerged; the presence of a clear middle ground of services suggests that these contexts may be presently experiencing shifts in their perceived tipping norms. Together, these pilot studies support our research motivation; that an increasing breadth of offerings are requesting tips, while also providing support for our assertion that consumers perceive tipping norms as varyingly applicable across contexts.

Study 1

We propose that our theory and observed effects are context-specific and reflective of consumer responses to tip prompts specifically in non-normative contexts. The possibility remains, however, that the effects we theorize may be reflective of a broader cultural shift in attitudes towards tipping more generally. Study 1 was thus designed to test whether our theory applies only to non-normative contexts. This study was preregistered (https://osf.io/nd2be/?view_only=fcefc9f2257c46b8adfdd35ff4fed533).

Procedure

Study 1 was a 2 (tip prompt vs. no prompt) x 2 (context: normative vs. non-normative) between-participants experiment for which 401 Canadian and American adult participants were recruited from Prolific in exchange for financial compensation. One participant failed an attention check, leaving a sample of 400 for analysis (M_{age} = 42.5, 49.8% female).

Participants first completed a visualization task. Participants in the non-normative context condition were asked to imagine going to a drive-thru café, placing an order, and then paying for

and receiving it before leaving. Below this description, participants were shown an image of an employee passing a point-of-purchase payment terminal through the drive-thru window with the display screen visible. For participants in the tip prompt condition, the display showed "Add a tip" with the options 10%, 15%, 18%, 20% and No Tip. Participants in the no prompt condition saw the same image, except the display instead showed a tap-to-pay icon with the text "Tap, Insert, Swipe". Participants in the normative context condition read about an experience at a casual dining restaurant where they experienced table service from a waiter and enjoyed their meal. Upon completing their meal, participants paid via card machine with tip prompt manipulated in the same manner as the non-normative conditions, using an image of a point-of-sale display screen (see Appendix A for full stimuli).

Following the visualization task, participants reported satisfaction (3 items, 7-point scale, adapted from Maxham & Netemeyer, 2002; $\alpha = .88$), word-of-mouth intentions (3 items, 7-point scale, adapted from Zeithaml *et al*., 1996; $\alpha = .93$), brand attitudes (3 items, 7-point scale, adapted from Batra & Stayman, 1990; $\alpha = .98$), and re-patronage intentions (2 items, 7-point scale, adapted from Aaker *et al*., 2012; $r = .94$). These four measures were presented in random order. Last, participants reported ecological validity ("the experience I read about felt realistic to me, as if it could occur in everyday life", 1 = strongly disagree, 7 = strongly agree), responded to a manipulation check ("were you asked for a tip when you made your purchase at the café?" 1 = definitely not, 7 = definitely yes), and reported demographics. An attention check (please select 1) was embedded in the word-of-mouth scale. See Appendix B for complete measures for each study.

Results

Manipulation check. A two-way ANOVA of the manipulation check revealed only a main effect of tip prompt condition (M_{Prompt} = 6.43, SD= 1.39, $M_{NoPrompt}$ = 1.99, SD = 1.62; $F(1, 396) = 794.32$, $p < .0001$). Neither the main effect of context ($F(1, 396) = .06$, $p = .80$) nor the interaction ($F(1, 396) = 1.08$, $p = .30$) were significant, suggesting that the tip prompt manipulation was effective.

Ecological validity. A two-way ANOVA of ecological validity revealed only a main effect of tip prompt condition (M_{Prompt} = 6.41, SD = .83, $M_{NoPrompt}$ = 6.17, SD = 1.16; $F(1, 395) = 5.61$, $p = .018$). Neither the main effect of context ($F(1, 395) = .07$, $p = .79$) nor the interaction ($F(1, 395) = .17$, $p = .68$) were significant, suggesting that both context conditions were seen as equally ecologically-valid. While being prompted for a tip was seen as more ecologically-valid than not, both of these conditions were significantly above the midpoint of the scale ($t_{Prompt}(202) = 41.42$, $p < .0001$; $t_{NoPrompt}(195) = 26.15$, $p < .0001$), indicating that participants could fluently visualize the scenario across all conditions.[1]

Dependent measures. A two-way MANOVA of satisfaction, word-of-mouth, brand attitudes, and re-patronage intentions as a function of tip prompt and context conditions revealed significant effects of both tip prompt ($F(1, 395) = 19.21$, $p < .0001$) and context ($F(1, 395) = 33.59$, $p < .0001$). Importantly, these effects were qualified by the expected interaction ($F(1, 395) = 16.75$, $p < .0001$; see Figure 3). Follow-up contrast analysis revealed a significant effect of tip prompt for participants in the non-normative (i.e., café; ($F(1, 395) = 35.47$, $p < .0001$) but not the normative (i.e., restaurant; $F(1, 395) = .04$, $p = .84$) condition. See Table 2 for univariate results for all studies.

[1] Ecological validity was also measured in studies 3 and 4. Results consistently showed high ecological validity of the paradigm (all condition means > 6.00).

[insert Figure 3 about here]

Discussion

Study 1 provides strong evidence that our theorized effects are bounded by context. Participants responded negatively to tip prompts (in the form of reduced satisfaction, word-of-mouth, brand attitudes, and re-patronage intentions) from a drive-thru café (i.e., a *non-normative* context) but did not show any negative response to tip prompts from a casual dining restaurant (i.e., a *normative* context). This suggests that consumers are discerning when it comes to the source of a tip prompt and the social norms regarding said prompt, supporting H1.

Study 2

Our theory suggests that consumers respond negatively to tip prompts experienced in non-normative contexts. This is because a tip prompt in a non-normative setting is unexpected and thus violates consumer norms and expectations. Study 2 was thus designed to conceptually replicate the findings of Study 1. Rather than manipulate context normativity, however, all participants imagined the non-normative scenario from Study 1 and then reported the extent to which the tip prompt was unexpected. We anticipated that negative responses to tip prompts would be more clearly observed when the prompt was unexpected (and thereby violated norms). That is, we expected degree of unexpectedness to moderate the effect of a tip prompt, such that greater unexpectedness would result in more negative consumer responses.

Procedure

Study 2 was a two-condition (tip prompt vs no prompt) between-participants experiment for which 362 American and Canadian adult participants were recruited from Prolific in exchange for financial compensation. Seven participants failed an attention check, leaving a sample of 355 for analysis (M_{age} = 40.69, 48.44% female).

Participants first completed the same visualization task as the non-normative condition in Study 1, where they imagined going to a drive-thru café. Following the visualization task, participants reported their satisfaction (α = .90), word-of-mouth intentions (α = .88), brand attitudes (α = .98), and re-patronage intentions (*r* = .92), all as per Study 1. Last, participants responded to a manipulation check ("were you asked for a tip when you made your purchase at the café?"; 1 = definitely not, 7 = definitely yes), and reported the extent to which they found/would have found it surprising (M = 3.43, SD = 2.14) and unexpected (M = 3.45, SD = 2.12; both 7-point scales anchored by 1 = not at all, 7 = extremely; *r* = .91) to have been asked for a tip in this situation. Participants were also asked the extent to which they were provided with customer service in the scenario (1 = none at all, 7 = extensive service provided) and demographics. An attention check (please select 1) was embedded in the word-of-mouth scale.

Results

Manipulation check. Those in the tip prompt condition (M = 6.12, SD = 1.63) indicated they had been more definitely asked for a tip than those in the no prompt condition (M = 2.28, SD = 1.94; $F(1, 353) = 407.23$, $p < .0001$). The tip prompt manipulation was effective.

Dependent measures. Replicating the results of Study 1, a MANOVA of satisfaction, word-of-mouth, brand attitudes, and re-patronage intentions as a function of tip prompt revealed

a significant effect of tip prompt ($F(1, 346) = 31.31$, $p < .0001$). Each dependent measure was significantly predicted by tip prompt (all ps < .003; see Table 2 for univariate results).

Moderation by Unexpectedness. We next conducted a MANOVA of satisfaction, word-of-mouth, brand attitudes, and re-patronage intentions as a function of tip prompt, unexpectedness (standardized to M = 0 and SD = 1), and their interaction. Omnibus test results demonstrated main effects of tip prompt ($F(1, 344) = 33.59$, $p < .0001$) and unexpectedness ($F(1, 344) = 23.15$, $p < .0001$). Importantly, these were qualified by a significant interaction between tip prompt and unexpectedness ($F(1, 344) = 6.69$, $p = .01$). The interaction pattern was characterized by a more strongly negative slope for the tip prompt condition than for the no prompt condition. Follow-up tests revealed a consistent pattern of results for each dependent measure, though the within-participants interaction effect ($F(3, 1032) = 2.84$, $p = .039$) was significant[i] (see Table 2).

[insert Figure 4 about here]

Discussion

Study 2 builds on study 1 by demonstrating additional support for H1: that consumers prompted to provide a tip respond negatively in terms of satisfaction, word-of-mouth, brand attitudes, and behavioral intentions. Importantly, Study 2 provides additional evidence that this effect is bounded by social norms: the negative responses to a tip prompt emerged only for those participants for whom a tip prompt was unexpected. This supports our theorizing that context normativity represents an important moderator of consumer response to tip prompts. Having

established the moderating role of context normativity, Study 3 seeks to determine the underlying cause of these negative responses.

Study 3

Study 3 was designed to i) replicate the negative effect of a tip prompt in a non-normative context (drive-thru café) on consumer outcomes (satisfaction, brand attitudes, word-of-mouth, and re-patronage intentions), and ii) test whether this effect arises as a function of heightened reactance. This study was pre-registered (*https://osf.io/dn247/?view_only=0fc6e6547c874028b9028a3fa3026025*).

Procedure

Study 3 was a two-condition (tip prompt vs no prompt) between-participants experiment for which 220 American and Canadian adult participants were recruited from Prolific in exchange for financial compensation. One participant failed an attention check, leaving a sample of 219 for analysis (M_{age} = 44.2, 50.2% female).

Participants completed the same visualization task as in Study 2. Following the visualization task, participants indicated their reactance (e.g., *"Please rate the extent to which the scenario made you feel like your choices were being taken away"*; 3 items, 100-point scales; adapted from Bertini and Aydinli, 2020[ii]). Participants then reported satisfaction (α = .96), word-of-mouth intentions (α = .88), brand attitudes (α = .98), and re-patronage intentions (*r* = .92) using the same items as per Study 1. Last, participants reported ecological validity and a manipulation check (both as per Study 1), provided demographics, and completed an open-ended attention check ("what were you doing an hour ago?"). An attention check (please select 1) was also embedded in the word-of-mouth scale.

Results

Manipulation check. Those in the tip prompt condition (M = 6.63, SD = .96) indicated they had been more definitely asked for a tip than those in the no prompt condition (M = 1.80, SD = 1.59; $F(1, 217) = 751.06$, $p < .0001$). The tip prompt manipulation was effective.

Dependent measures. A MANOVA of satisfaction, word-of-mouth, brand attitudes, and re-patronage intentions as a function of tip prompt revealed a significant effect of the tip prompt manipulation ($F(1, 214) = 40.13$, $p < .0001$). Each dependent variable was predicted by tip prompt (all ps < .0003; see Table 2 for univariate results).

Reactance. For ease of interpretation, reactance was converted to a 7-point scale. An ANOVA of reactance as a function of tip prompt condition was significant ($F(1, 217) = 54.93$, $p < .0001$). Prompting a tip (M = 2.53, SD = 2.31) induced greater reactance than not prompting a tip (M = .81, SD = 1.24).

Mediation. Hayes' Process macro (2022; model 4, 10,000 bootstrap) was used to test for mediation, with tip prompt condition as the independent variable, reactance as the mediator, and a composite average of the four dependent variables as the dependent variable. This revealed a significant indirect effect of tip prompt on the dependent variables, through reactance (indirect effect = -.57, 95% CI: -.80, -.37). Univariate mediation tests for each dependent measure demonstrated the same significant mediating effect (see Table 2).

[insert Figure 5 about here]

Discussion

Study 3 replicated the findings of studies 1 and 2; in a non-normative tipping context, participants prompted to provide a tip reported less favorable consumer outcomes. Importantly, study 3 extends these findings by also providing evidence that reduced outcomes occur as a function of elevated reactance to receiving a tip prompt in this context. That is, consumers reacted against the tip prompt; they felt like they were being forced to act against their will. This reactance then manifested in the range of negative outcomes reported.

Study 4

Study 4 was designed to address the question of whether negative effects associated with tip prompts in non-normative contexts can be mitigated if front line employees intervene to increase consumers' autonomy. This study was pre-registered (https://osf.io/2wz57/?view_only=6cbf57e4ca674b2b88b4b06524f569aa)

Procedure

Study 4 was a three-condition (tip prompt vs no prompt vs ignore prompt) between-participants experiment for which 300 American and Canadian adult participants were recruited from Prolific in exchange for financial compensation. Five participants failed an attention check, leaving a sample of 295 for analysis (M_{age} = 42.8, 53.9% female).

Participants in the tip prompt and no prompt conditions completed the same visualization task (scenario and image) as in study 2. Participants in the ignore condition completed the same visualization task as the tip prompt condition with the additional line: *As the barista hands you*

the card machine through the window they say "just choose No Tip first, then pay on the next screen" (see Appendix A for complete stimuli).

Following the visualization task, participants reported reactance (α = .95), satisfaction (α = .90), word-of-mouth intentions (α = .92), brand attitudes (α = .97), and re-patronage intentions (r = .94). Last, participants completed the same ecological validity check, tip manipulation check, and demographics items (all items as per Study 1). An attention check (please select 1) was embedded in the word-of-mouth scale.

Results

Manipulation check. An ANOVA of the manipulation check as a function of condition was significant ($F(2, 292) = 239.83$, $p < .0001$). Follow-up contrast analyses showed those in the tip prompt condition (M = 6.80, SD = .59) indicated they had been more definitely asked for a tip than those in the no prompt condition (M = 2.11, SD = 1.90; $F(1, 292) = 381.93$, $p < .0001$) and those in the ignore condition (M = 2.43, SD = 2.12; $F(1, 292) = 334.81$, $p < .0001$), which did not differ from each other ($F(1, 292) = 1.79$, $p = .18$). This suggests that the interventional instruction to ignore the tip shifted customer perceptions of being asked for a tip.

Dependent measures. A MANOVA of satisfaction, word-of-mouth, brand attitudes, and re-patronage intentions as a function of tip prompt condition revealed a significant effect of tip prompt ($F(2, 284) = 34.48$, $p < .0001$). Follow-up contrast analyses revealed that this effect was driven by substantially more negative outcomes in the tip prompt condition than in either the no prompt ($F(1, 284) = 51.36$, $p < .0001$) or ignore ($F(1, 284) = 52.00$, $p < .0001$) conditions, which did not differ ($F(1, 284) = 0.00$, $p = .99$; see Table 2 for univariate results).

Reactance. An ANOVA of reactance as a function of tip prompt condition was significant ($F(2, 292) = 12.40$, $p < .0001$). Follow-up contrast analyses showed that this effect

was driven by elevated reactance in the tip prompt condition (M = 2.45, SD = 2.32) relative to the no prompt (M = 1.07, SD = 1.79; $F(1, 292) = 23.82$, $p < .0001$) and ignore prompt (M = 1.52, SD = 1.74; $F(1, 292) = 10.80$, $p = .001$) conditions, which did not differ from each other ($F(1, 292) = 2.60$, $p = .11$).

Mediation. To test for mediation, a composite of the four dependent variables was created by averaging the four scales. Two mediation models were then tested using Hayes' Process macro (model 4, 10,000 bootstraps) with reactance as the mediator and the composite outcome measure as the dependent variable. First, to confirm the results from Study 3, we tested a model comparing the tip prompt condition (coded as 1) vs. the no prompt condition (coded as 0), which showed significant mediation (indirect effect = -.53, 95% CI: -.76, -.32). Next, we tested a model comparing the tip prompt condition (coded as 1) versus the ignore prompt condition (coded as 0), which showed significant mediation (indirect effect = -.32, 95% CI: -.52, -.12). Univariate mediation tests for each dependent measure demonstrated the same significant mediating effects (see Table 2).

[insert Figure 6 about here]

Discussion

Study 4 replicates the findings of the prior three studies in support of H1 and H2: a tip prompt led to negative consumer outcomes, and this effect was mediated by consumer reactance. Importantly, Study 4 builds on these findings by demonstrating that the negative effects of a tip prompt can be mitigated if consumers' sense of autonomy is reinforced by the tip-prompting organization. Specifically, we found that a frontline employee's suggestion to ignore the tip prompt mitigated the negative effects of the tip prompt. This provides additional evidence in

support of our theory that consumer reactance is a key underlying psychological mechanism of consumers' responses to tip prompts in non-normative contexts.

Discussion

Across two pilot studies and four experimental studies we describe modern tipping norms and show that tip prompts in non-normative contexts can lead to negative consumer evaluations. Studies 1 and 2 demonstrate that context matters: tip prompts perceived as non-normative induce negative consumer effects relative to tip prompts in a normative context (i.e., sit-down restaurant; study 1) or tip prompts in a non-normative context (i.e., drive-thru) that are nevertheless expected (study 2). Study 3 then demonstrates the important role that consumer reactance plays in this process as an underlying psychological mechanism: consumers react against the perceived persuasion attempt. Study 4 replicates mediation findings and further demonstrates that frontline employees can shift consumer perceptions of having been prompted for a tip, thereby mitigating the negative effects of a tip prompt.

Theoretical Contribution

The present research makes several theoretical contributions to marketing literature. First, we contribute to the service and consumer behavior literature on tipping practices by highlighting the potential impact of simply prompting a consumer to provide a tip. Most recent tipping research has focused on factors such as tip magnitude suggestions (e.g., Alexander *et al*., 2021; Haggag & Paci, 2014; Hoover, 2022) or other gratuity guidelines (Cabano and Attari, 2023). These findings typically i) explore attributes of tip prompts and/or their framing, and ii) focus on tip volume as the outcome of interest. Our research highlights that consumers are

sensitive not just to the framing of a request for a tip, but the act of soliciting a tip altogether. Our work thus builds on Warren & Hanson's (2023) conceptual framework regarding tipping-based outcomes of point-of-sale technologies, which discusses how a tip prompt could potentially trigger negative consumer responses. We empirically confirm this theorizing but also qualify Warren & Hanson's framework by highlighting the important role that contextual norms play as a boundary condition for these phenomena. Our findings contribute to the service marketing literature on service encounter design (Bitner 1992) and technology-mediated payment interactions (Meuter et al. 2000) by demonstrating that seemingly minor elements, such as tip prompts, can shape customers evaluations of the service experience. We show that these elements can influence not only transactional outcomes but also downstream relational outcomes.

Following this, we contribute to the literature on tipping norms. While social norms are well-recognized as motivating tipping behaviors (e.g., Azar 2003; Furnham 2021; Lee *et al*., 2020), relatively little research describes the exact nature of these norms. This gap becomes further accentuated when considering business' evolving tipping practices. We draw on Bicchieri's (2016) theory of social norms to theorize that the underlying 'reasons' for tipping norms are less applicable to non-normative contexts. This results in consumers not perceiving tipping norms as applicable to the same extent in these contexts. Our pilot studies provide support for this theorizing by demonstrating that consumers discern between contexts as well as employee role when evaluating the extent to which tipping is normative in a given context. This contribution also speaks to the service literature on role expectations and service scripts. Service encounters are governed by shared expectations regarding what customers and employees are each responsible for contributing to the exchange (Solomon et al. 1985). Our findings suggest

that when firms introduce practice that conflict with normative expectations (such as requesting tips where personalized service is minimal), customers may question the legitimacy of the exchange.

Finally, the present research also contributes to the tipping literature by introducing psychological reactance as a mechanism to links non-normative tip prompts to negative consumer outcomes. Prior research has demonstrated that marketing actions, such as promotional favors (Bertini & Aydinli, 2020), loyalty programs (Kivetz, 2005), and product stockouts (Fitzsimons, 2000), can produce consumer reactance, and thus lead to negative outcomes for firms. We show that tip prompts can similarly function as autonomy-threatening influence attempts when they are deployed in non-normative contexts, thereby extending reactance theory into the domain of service pricing and gratuity practices. In doing so, this contribution advances prior work on customer irritation (Karabas et al. 2020) by demonstrating that consumers' responses to tip prompts reflect not merely annoyance, but a deeper motivational resistance to perceived coercion that results in broader and more consequential downstream outcomes, including diminished satisfaction, brand attitudes, word-of-mouth, and repatronage intentions. This finding contributes to the service marketing literature on consumer resistance to firm influence within service encounters. While reactance has been examined in promotional and pricing contexts (e.g., Clee and Wicklund 1980; Bertini and Aydinli 2020) and consumers react negatively when service design restricts their autonomy (Hui & Bateson 1991), our research demonstrates such negative responses can arise from seemingly small service practices such as tip prompts within routine consumer transactions.

Managerial Implications

The findings of this research are pertinent for marketers and managers in the retail or service industry. Notably, this research is of timely relevance to the current marketplace because of changing tipping norms (Warren & Hanson, 2023). Whereas previous findings have shown that consumer tips may motivate employees to provide enhanced customer service (Kwortnik *et al*., 2009) and increase employee retention rates (Lynn *et al*., 2011), the present research demonstrates negative implications of presenting consumers with tip prompts. Our findings suggest that, when said prompts are perceived as non-normative, consumers view these prompts as unwelcome impositions that threaten their perceived autonomy, ultimately contributing to negative attitudes and behaviors toward firm. A simple diagnostic question for managers should thus be: "is tipping normative in this context?" As the tipping landscape continues to evolve (see Pilot Studies 1 and 2), managers may be best served by assessing perceived normativity directly, perhaps via customer survey ("how normal would it be to tip in this setting?"). Contexts scoring below the midpoint of normativity may be more vulnerable to consumer reactance to tip prompts, and should consider avoiding or removing such prompts from their payment processes. It is quite possible that, for these firms, long term costs (i.e. negative consumer attitudes towards the brand) outweigh short-term benefits (i.e. increased tip revenues). Notably, many service managers (e.g., branch or franchise managers) may not always control tip prompt processes. For these managers, our findings suggest that frontline employees may be able to mitigate negative consumer responses to tip prompts by recommending the consumer ignore the prompt (Study 4). Given this finding, managers may want to consider revising service scripts to incorporate autonomy-supportive language such as "You can skip the tip screen if you'd like" or "Just press 'no tip' and continue" given that these options can reinforce customer choice.

Limitations and Further Research

There are several limitations of this research that prompt future opportunities for extension. First, the present work investigated tipping at drive-thru cafés and casual dining restaurants. Future research should investigate the generalizability of the findings presented in this research across other non-normative tipping contexts. This is particularly important to examine as an increasing number of businesses across a wide array of industries implement tip prompts as part of their service settings (see Pilot Study 1). Second, it is also important to consider that the current research employed a North American sample. As tipping norms differ between different cultures and regions around the world (Azar, 2020), future research should investigate the cross-cultural replicability of our findings. Third, the present research relied on online scenario-based studies to test our theory. Future research confirming our findings in a field setting would thus be valuable.

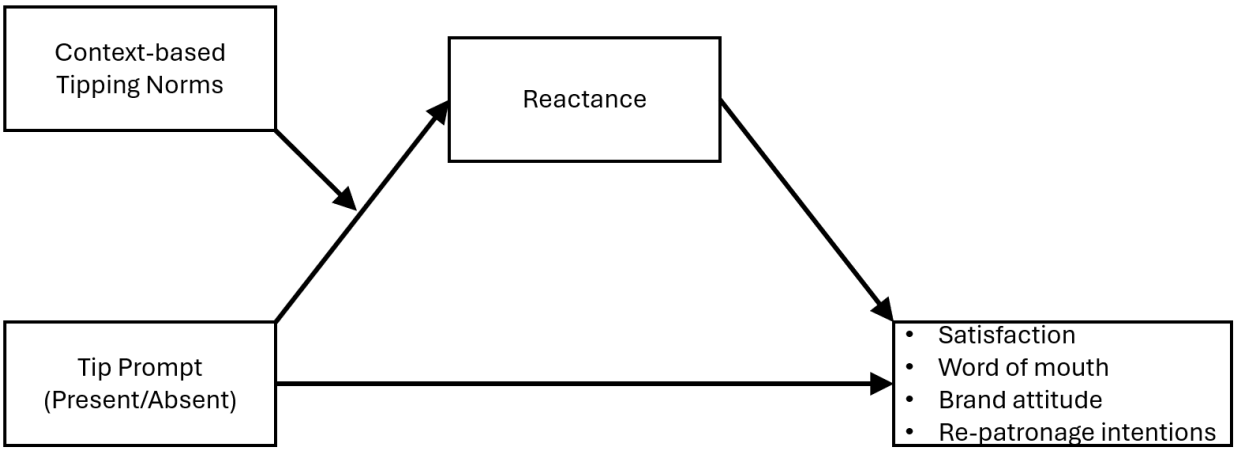
Our findings also suggest potentially fruitful opportunities for future research. Specifically, our identification of reactance as a central consumer response to tip prompts suggests potential value in revisiting past findings through a reactance lens. For example, might the relationship between service quality, tipping, and consumer evaluations be better explained by considering reactance? And while our theoretical and empirical evidence points to reactance as the key underlying mechanism, it is possible that some consumers may experience other forms of threat, such as moral (denying a lower wage service worker in need) or identity-based (does not tipping make me a bad person?) threats. Future research should explore these possibilities.

The proliferation of tip prompts in non-normative contexts may, over time, produce negative implications for society at large. That is, repeated exposure to tip prompts in non-normative contexts could reasonably lead consumers to experience reactance to tip prompts to such an extent that they start reacting to otherwise-normative tip prompts as well. This may

present as tip fatigue and could lead to an erosion of tipping norms, destabilizing an important source of supplemental revenue for firms and (often low-wage) employees alike. In sum, it is possible that a desire to secure incremental revenue in the form of tips in non-normative contexts could have a long-term negative effect on consumer perceptions of tipping more broadly and this is worthy of additional study.

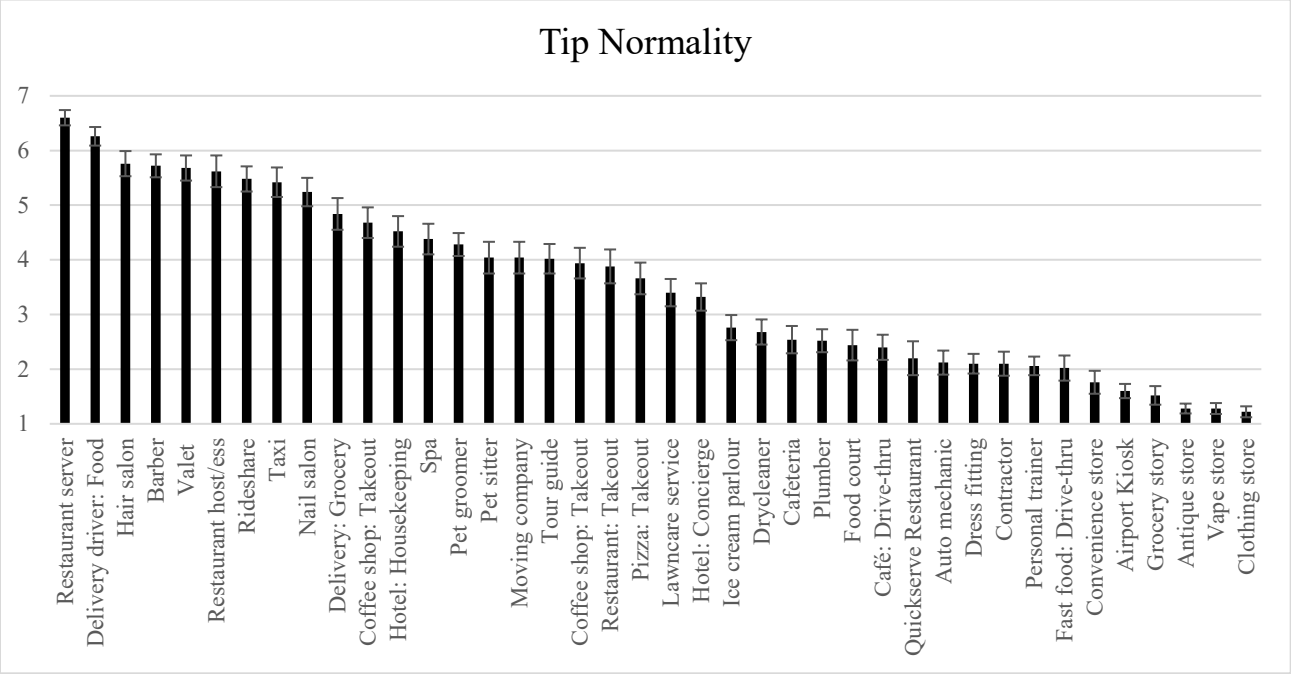
Additionally, Study 4 identifies one potential intervention that can mitigate consumers' reactance responses to tip prompts. Given the need for balance between the short term financial benefits of tipping for firms and employees and the longer-term risks associated with non-normative tipping contexts, future research could explore other strategies that mitigate or ameliorate reactance while preserving consumer autonomy. For instance, prior research has found that small gestures like giving candy to customers can positively impact tip amounts (Strohmetz *et al*., 2002); such practices may also help offset consumer reactance. Similarly, research in choice architecture (Thaler & Sunstein, 2008) regarding when and how to prompt consumers to ignore a tip request might be an additional avenue for exploration. Consumers might be differentially impacted by a prompt that comes from an individual rather than a machine, as an example. Finally, while not a focus of Study 1, we found that those in the tip prompt condition (M = 4.34 SD = 1.52) indicated they had received less customer service than those in the no prompt condition (M = 4.75, SD = 1.37; $F(1, 353) = 7.10$, $p = .008$). Future research should explore whether such evaluations are halo effects or represent a true re-characterization of the nature of service received.

Figure 1 – Conceptual Model of Consumer Responses to Tip Prompts



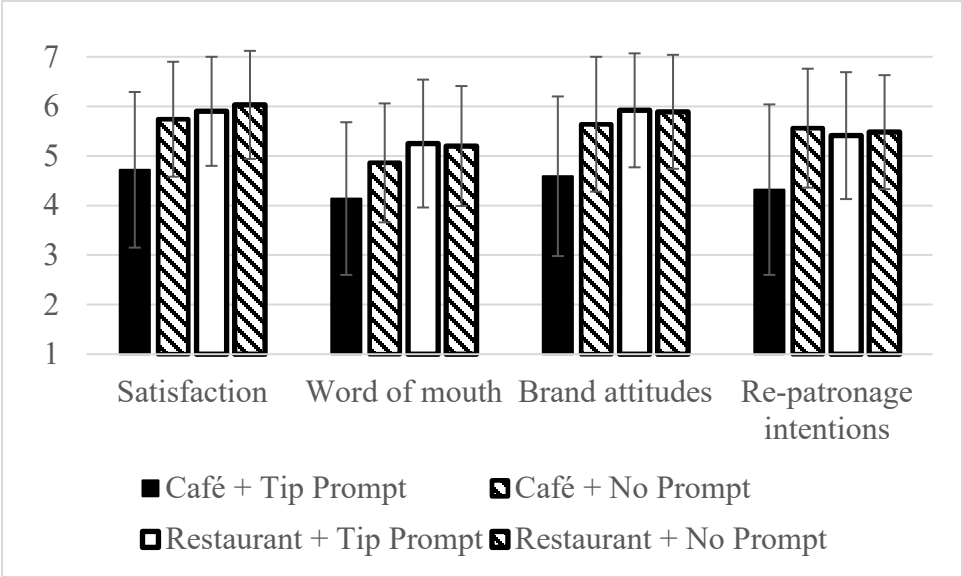
Source: Authors' own work

Figure 2. Pilot Study 2 Tip Contexts Reported Rank-ordered by Normality



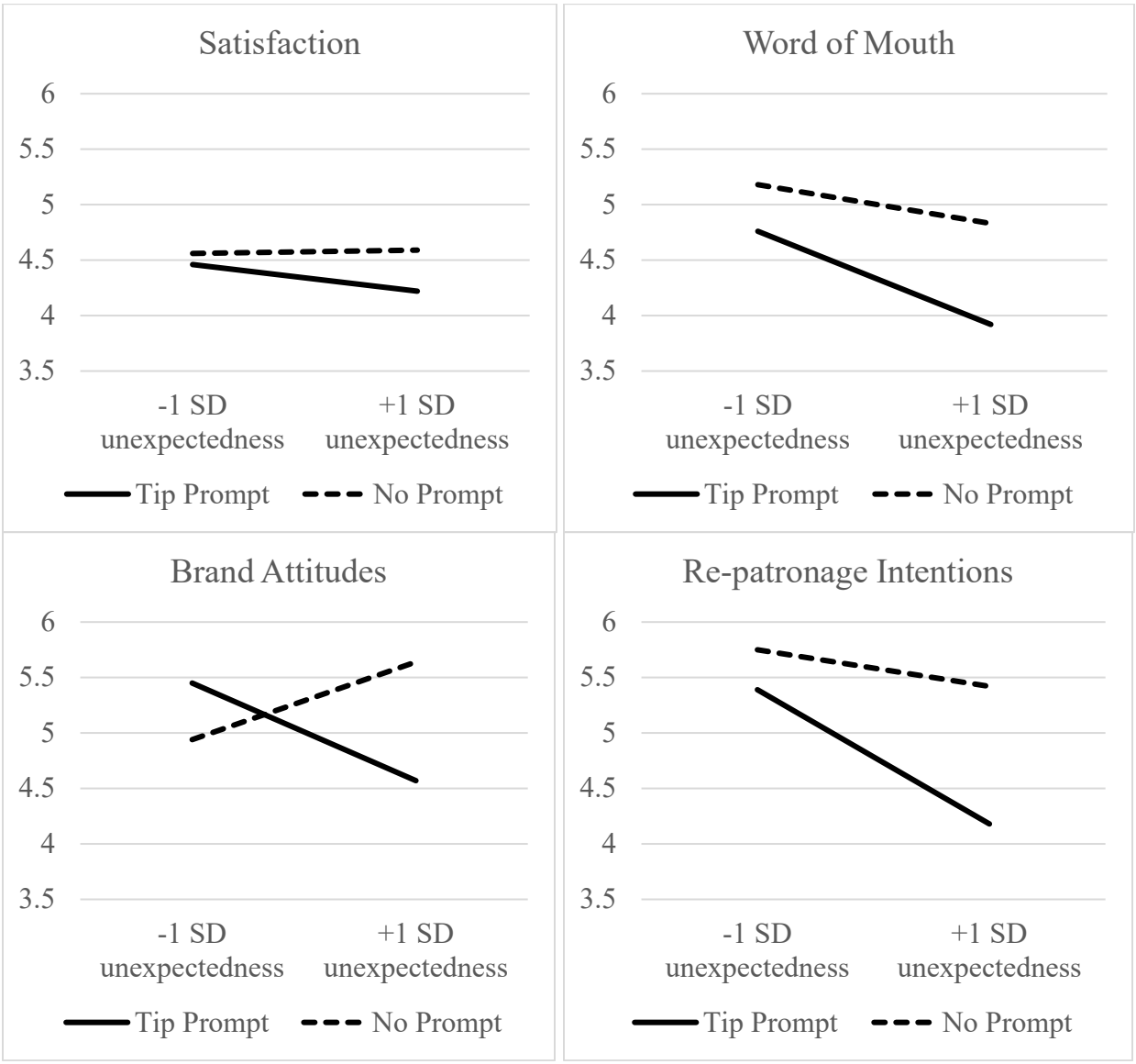
Note: Factor analysis cannot be conducted because each participant only completed 10 contexts. Error bars represent standard errors.
Source: Authors' own work.

Figure 3 – Study 1 Univariate Results: Means and Standard Deviations



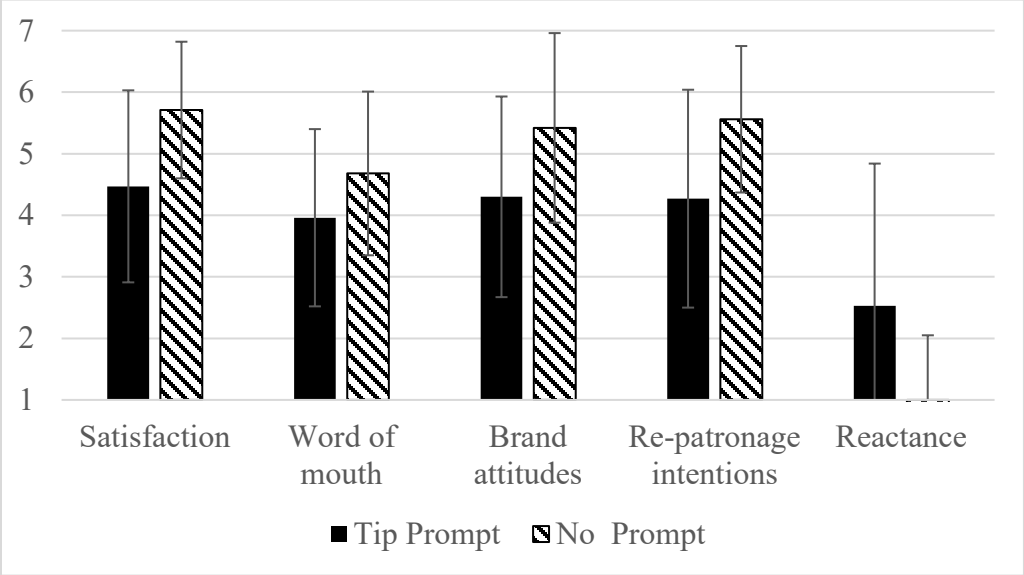
Source: Authors' own work.

Figure 4 – Study 2 Univariate Interaction Results



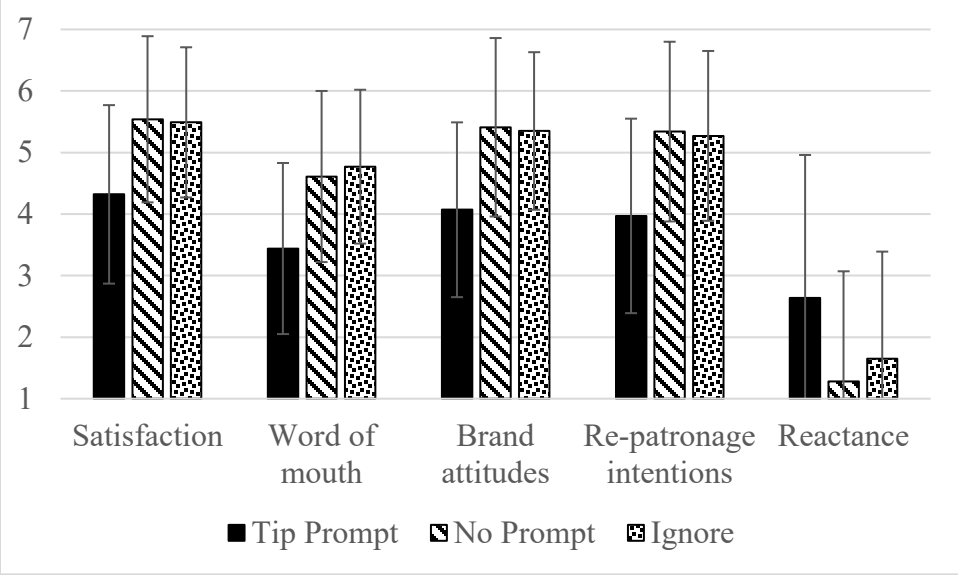
Source: Authors' own work.

Figure 5 – Study 3 Univariate Results: Means and Standard Deviations



Source: Authors' own work.

Figure 6 – Study 4 Univariate Results: Means and Standard Deviations



Source: Authors' own work.

Table 1. Tip request contexts from Pilot Study 1

Food and Beverage	**Retail**	**Personal Services**	**Entertainment**
Restaurant server (sit-down restaurant)	Airport kiosk (retail)	*Transportation*	Casino
Restaurant host/hostess (sit-down restaurant)	Vape Store/Dispensary	Ride-share (e.g., Uber)	Strip club
Restaurant - take out order	"Round up" request, retailer	Taxi	Tour guide
Pizza take-out (e.g., Domino's)	Neighborhood convenience store	Valet service	
Fast food/quick-serve restaurant	Phone kiosk	*Grooming*	**Accommodations**
Cafeteria	Antique collectible store	Barber	Hotel housekeeping
Food court	Clothing store	Hair salon	Hotel concierge
Food truck		Nail salon	
Ice cream parlour	**Tradesperson**	Spa	
Bar	Auto mechanic	*Pets*	
Coffee shop (sit down)	Plumber	Pet sitter	
Coffee shop - take out counter service		Pet groomer	
Drive thru café/fast food		*Homecare*	
Delivery driver (prepared food)		Lawn maintenance	
Delivery driver (groceries)			

Source: Authors' own work.

Table 2 – Univariate Statistics by study and condition

	Café		Restaurant		Interaction *F*
Study 1	Tip Prompt	No Prompt	Tip Prompt	No Prompt	
Satisfaction	4.72 (1.57)	5.74 (1.16)	5.90 (1.10)	6.03 (1.09)	12.34***
Word of mouth	4.14 (1.54)	4.86 (1.20)	5.25 (1.29)	5.20 (1.21)	8.37**
Brand attitudes	4.59 (1.61)	5.64 (1.36)	5.92 (1.15)	5.89 (1.15)	16.12***
Re-patronage intentions	4.32 (1.72)	5.56 (1.20)	5.41 (1.28)	5.48 (1.15)	18.60***

Study 2	Tip Prompt	No Prompt	*F*-statistic
Satisfaction	4.34 (.76)	4.58 (.71)	9.14**
Word of mouth	4.34 (1.40)	5.01 (1.31)	21.46***
Brand attitudes	4.01 (1.51)	5.79 (1.13)	29.89***
Re-patronage intentions	4.78 (1.52)	5.59 (1.15)	30.86***

	Low unexpected (-1 SD)		High unexpected (+1 SD)		Interaction *F*
	Tip Prompt	No Prompt	Tip Prompt	No Prompt	
Satisfaction	4.46 (.08)	4.56 (.08)	4.22 (.08)	4.59 (.08)	2.80^
Word of mouth	4.76 (.14)	5.18 (.14)	3.92 (.14)	4.83 (.14)	2.91^
Brand attitudes	5.45 (.14)	4.94 (.14)	4.57 (.14)	5.64 (.14)	4.34*
Re-patronage intentions	5.39 (.13)	5.75 (.14)	4.18 (.13)	5.42 (.14)	10.69**

Study 3	Tip Prompt	No Prompt	*F*-statistic	*Indirect effect*
Satisfaction	4.47 (1.56)	5.71 (1.11)	45.36***	-.73 [-.97, -.49]
Word of mouth	3.96 (1.44)	4.68 (1.33)	14.36***	-.37 [-.59, -.19]
Brand attitudes	4.30 (1.63)	5.42 (1.54)	26.86***	-.52 [-.76, -.29]
Re-patronage intentions	4.27 (1.77)	5.56 (1.19)	39.49***	-.65 [-.92, -.41]

Study 4	Univariate				Contrast Analysis (*F*-statistics)		
	Tip Prompt	Ignore	No Prompt	Overall *F*	Tip v Ignore	Tip v No Tip	Ignore v No Tip
Satisfaction	4.32 (1.45)	5.49 (1.22)	5.54 (1.35)	25.32***	36.72***	39.13***	0.06
Word of mouth	3.44 (1.39)	4.77 (1.25)	1.61 (1.39)	27.94***	47.29***	35.63***	0.73
Brand attitudes	4.07 (1.42)	5.35 (1.28)	5.41 (1.45)	28.64***	41.24***	44.55***	0.09
Re-patronage intentions	3.97 (1.58)	5.27 (1.38)	5.34 (1.46)	25.93***	37.17***	40.48***	0.10

Indirect effect	Tip v Ignore	Tip v No Tip
Satisfaction	-.35 [-.58, -.13]	-.61 [-.87, -.35]
Word of mouth	-.19 [-.34, -.07]	-.30 [-.48, -.15]
Brand attitudes	-.31 [-.52, -.11]	-.53 [-.78, -.30]
Re-patronage intentions	-.35 [-.59, -.12]	-.60 [-.88, -.34]

^ = <.10, * = <.05, ** = <.01, *** = <.001

Source: Authors' own work.

APPENDIX A - Stimuli

Studies 1, 2, 3, 4 - Prompt and No Prompt conditions, non-normative context

Imagine you're running errands and decide you want to stop for a coffee. You see a cafe down the road and decide to go through the drive-thru.

You pull into the drive-thru lane and wait in line behind other cars. You get to the front of the line and now it's your turn to order.

Through the intercom, the barista greets you and asks to take your order. You tell the barista your order and they confirm your order by repeating it back to you. Then the barista tells you your subtotal and asks you to drive up to the next window.

You drive up to the window and the barista asks how you will be paying. You say that you will be paying by card. The barista hands you the card machine through the window.

You look down and see the following screen. You make your selection and pay. The barista then hands you your drink and you drive away.

Prompt Condition



No Prompt Condition



Study 1 – Normative context, Prompt and No Prompt conditions

Imagine you're out for dinner at a casual dining restaurant. You sit down and are provided with a glass of water and a menu.

After perusing the menu, you place your order. The waiter confirms your order and takes it to the kitchen.

After a normal wait, your food arrives. You enjoy your meal, and the waiter checks in a couple times to ensure you have everything you need.

You finish your meal and ask for the bill. The waiter asks how you will be paying. You say that you will be paying by card. The waiter hands you the card machine.

You look down and see the following screen. You make your selection and pay. The waiter provides you with your bill and wishes you a pleasant evening as you leave.

Prompt Condition



No Prompt Condition



Study 4 – Ignore Prompt condition

Imagine you're running errands and decide you want to stop for a coffee. You see a cafe down the road and decide to go through the drive-thru.

You pull into the drive-thru lane and wait in line behind other cars. You get to the front of the line and now it's your turn to order.

Through the intercom, the barista greets you and asks to take your order. You tell the barista your order and they confirm your order by repeating it back to you. Then the barista tells you your subtotal and asks you to drive up to the next window.

You drive up to the window and the barista asks how you will be paying. You say that you will be paying by card. As the barista hands you the card machine through the window they say "just choose No Tip first, then pay on the next screen".

You look down and see the following screen. You make your selection and pay. The barista then hands you your drink and you drive away.



APPENDIX B - Measures

Note: For applicable measures, "café" was replaced with "restaurant" for participants in a restaurant condition in study 1.

Reactance (Studies 3 and 4; adapted from Bertini and Aydinli, 2020)

Please rate the extent to which the scenario made you feel each of the below, where 0 means "not at all" and 100 means "a lot"; 100 point slider scale

- Like your choices were being taken away
- Like you didn't have any freedom
- Like you were trapped*

*reported means converted these three items to 7-point scales

Satisfaction (Studies 1—4; adapted from Maxham and Netemeyer, 2002)

- I am satisfied with my overall experience with this café (1 = strongly disagree, 7 = strongly agree)
- As a whole, I am *not* satisfied with this café (1 = strongly disagree, 7 = strongly agree)
- How satisfied are you overall with the quality of this café (1 = not at all satisfied, 7 = very satisfied)

Word of Mouth (Studies 1—4; 7-point scale anchored by 1 = not at all, 7 = extremely; adapted from Zeithaml *et al.*, 1996)

Please indicate the extent to which you are likely to…

- Recommend the café to someone you know
- Tell people good things about the café
- Share information about the café to someone you know

Brand attitudes (Studies 1—4; 7-point, bipolar scale; adapted from Batra and Stayman, 1990)

Overall, how would you rate the café?

- Unpleasant – Pleasant
- Bad – Good
- Negative – Positive

Re-patronage intentions (Studies 1—4; 7-point scale anchored by 1 = not at all, 7 = extremely; adapted from Aaker *et al.*, 2012)

Please indicate how likely you are to do each of the following

- To buy from the café if you had a need to visit a café during the next 30 days
- Shop at the café again

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[i] As outlined in Table 2, while the pattern of results was consistent across dependent measures, the interaction effect was strongest for re-patronage intentions ($p = .001$) and brand attitudes ($p = .038$) and weaker for satisfaction ($p = .095$) and word-of-mouth ($p = .0891$).

[ii] Two additional items measuring anger and frustration (Bertini and Aydinli 2020) were incorrectly attributed to this reactance scale and preregistered as such. For transparency, results for S2 and S3 are re-analyzed with these items appended to the reactance measure in the web appendix. No substantive differences were observed.